

Definition, Benefits, and How to Practice

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What to Know About Mindfulness Meditation

Notice your thoughts and get grounded

Mindfulness meditation is a mental training practice that teaches you to slow down racing thoughts, let go of negativity, and calm both your mind and body. It combines [meditation](#) with the practice of [mindfulness](#), which can be defined as a mental state that involves being fully focused on "the now" so you can acknowledge and accept your thoughts, feelings, and sensations without judgment.

Techniques can vary, but in general, mindfulness meditation involves [deep breathing](#) and [awareness](#) of body and mind. Practicing mindfulness meditation doesn't require props or preparation (no need for candles, essential oils, or mantras, unless you enjoy them). To get started, all you need is a comfortable place to sit, three to five minutes of free time, and a judgment-free mindset.

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How to Practice Mindfulness Meditation

Learning mindfulness meditation is simple enough to practice alone, but a teacher or program might help you begin, especially if you're practicing [meditation](#) for specific health reasons. Here are some easy steps to help you get started.

Get Comfortable

Find a quiet, comfortable spot. Sit on a chair or the floor with your head, neck, and back straight but relaxed. Wearing loose, comfortable clothes can also help you focus.

But being that this practice can be done anywhere for any amount of time, a dress code is not required.

Consider a Timer

While it's not necessary, a timer (preferably with a soft, gentle alarm) can help you focus on meditation and forget about time—and eliminate any excuses you have for stopping and doing something else.

Since many people lose track of time while meditating, it can also ensure you're not meditating for too long. Be sure to also allow yourself time after meditation to become aware of where you are and get up gradually.

While some people meditate for longer sessions, even a few minutes every day can make a difference. Begin with a short, [5-minute meditation session](#) and increase your sessions by 10 or 15 minutes until you are comfortable meditating for 30 minutes at a time.

Focus on Breathing

Become aware of your breath, attuning to the sensation of air moving in and out of your body as you breathe. Feel your belly rise and fall as the air enters your nostrils and leaves your nostrils. Pay attention to the temperature change when the breath is inhaled versus when it's exhaled.

Notice Your Thoughts

The aim isn't to stop your thoughts but to become more comfortable observing them. When thoughts arise, don't ignore or suppress them. Just note them calmly and use your breathing as an anchor. Imagine your thoughts as clouds passing by; watch them shift and change. Repeat this process as often as needed while meditating.

Give Yourself a Break

If you find yourself getting carried away in your thoughts—whether with worry, fear, anxiety, or hope—observe where your mind went, without judgment, and just return to your breathing. Don't be hard on yourself if this happens; the practice of returning to your breath and refocusing on the present is the practice of mindfulness.

Download an App

If you're having trouble practicing mindfulness meditation on your own, consider [downloading an app](#) (like Calm or Headspace) that provides free meditations and teaches you a variety of tools to help you get centered throughout your day.

Remember, meditation is a practice, so it's never perfect. You are ready to begin now, just as you are. Try our free mindfulness meditation below to get started.

Meditation: Pairing Mindfulness with Gratitude

Impact of Mindfulness Meditation

Regular practice of mindfulness meditation benefits both your physical and mental health. These benefits include:

- **Reducing stress:** [Mindfulness-based stress reduction \(MBSR\)](#), a standardized therapeutic approach to mindfulness meditation, has been shown to reduce symptoms of stress in healthy individuals.¹ The practice has also been found to be beneficial for a number of mental and physical disorders including anxiety, [depression](#), and chronic pain.
- **Lower heart rate:** Heart disease is one of the top causes of death in the United States and research suggests that mindfulness may be beneficial for your heart. In one meta-analysis of 45 studies, individuals who tried meditation exhibited lower heart rates and blood pressure, and exhibited fewer markers of stress overall.²
- **Improved immunity:** Research also suggests that mindfulness practices may improve your body's resistance to illness. One study compared the impact of both mindfulness and exercise on immune function.³ They found that people who had taken part in an eight-week mindfulness course had fewer days missed at work than those in the exercise and control groups.
- **Better sleep:** Studies have also shown that practicing mindfulness meditation might improve sleep and even be useful for treating certain sleep disturbances. One 2019 study found that mindfulness meditation significantly improved sleep quality.⁴

Making mindfulness meditation a regular practice can lead to stronger effects, but that doesn't necessarily mean that you need to do it every day. Studies have found that meditating three to four times per week can have big benefits—and, regularly meditating for eight weeks will actually alter the brain, according to neuroimaging studies.⁵

Tips to Practice Mindfulness in Daily Life

As you practice mindfulness meditation, it helps to find ways to [bring mindfulness into your everyday life](#)—especially on those days when life is too busy to carve out a minute alone. Mindfulness meditation is one technique, but everyday activities and tasks provide plenty of opportunities for mindfulness practice.

- **Brushing your teeth:** Feel your feet on the floor, the brush in your hand, and your arm moving up and down.
- **Doing dishes:** Savor the feeling of the warm water on your hands, the look of the bubbles, and the sounds of the pans clunking on the bottom of the sink.

- **Doing laundry:** Pay attention to the smell of the clean clothes and the feel of the fabric. Add a focus element and count your breaths as you fold laundry.
- **Driving:** Turn off the radio—or put on something soothing, like classical music. Imagine your spine growing tall, find the half-way point between relaxing your hands and gripping the wheel too tightly. Whenever you notice your mind wandering, bring your attention back to where you and your car are in space.
- **Exercising:** Instead of watching television while on the treadmill, try focusing on your breathing and where your feet are as you move.
- **Getting kids ready for bed:** Get down to the same level as your kids, look in their eyes, listen more than you talk, and savor any snuggles. When you relax, they will too.